SYDNEY, AUSTRALIA

Art Gallery of New South Wales: Masterpieces

Twenty works move between open country, city streets and the people given a place within them.



A broad landscape can make its people seem incidental. A railway station can scatter them across wet ground, while a ceremonial picture may organise every body into a rank. This selection invites attention to those choices of scale and placement, from Streeton's river valley to a small family under towering ferns.

The views are made, not simply found. Colour can bring a coast into order, a reflected tree can close a billabong, and columns can organise an imagined ancient court. Portraits offer a counterweight: a face and a few held gestures can claim the space that landscape elsewhere gives to hills or sky. The guide traces those changes without treating the selection as a complete account of the collection.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/art-gallery-new-south-wales

The selection · 20

1. Still Glides the Stream, and Shall for Ever Glide
   Arthur Streeton · 1890
2. The Railway Station, Redfern
   Arthur Streeton · 1893
3. From My Camp (Sirius Cove)
   Arthur Streeton · 1896
4. Antibes
   John Russell · 1890-1892
5. Rough Sea, Morestil
   John Russell · 1900
6. Mon Ami 'Polite
   John Russell · 1900
7. The Parish Hall
   Dorrit Black · 1937
8. Elizabeth Street, Sydney
   Dorrit Black · 1939
9. Naval Funeral
   Dorrit Black · 1945
10. David's First Victory
    William Strutt · 1868
11. Fern Gully with Aboriginal Family
    Thomas Clark · 1863
12. A Billabong of the Goulburn, Victoria
    Henry James Johnstone · 1884
13. Stalagmites, Burragalong Cavern
    Conrad Martens · 1843
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15. Portrait of Inez Bensusan
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16. Waiting
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17. The Visit of the Queen of Sheba to King Solomon
    Sir Edward John Poynter · 1890
18. Snowdrop and the Seven Little Men
    John D. Batten · 1897
19. Mucius Scaevola
    Matthias Stom · c.1640 - c. 1645
20. At Lilydale
    Louis Buvelot · 1870

01 / 20

Still Glides the Stream, and Shall for Ever Glide

Arthur Streeton

1890 · Oil on canvas, later mounted on hardboard · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Arthur Streeton. Still glides the stream, and shall for ever glide. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Full source frame, proportional resize and JPEG compression. https://www.wikiart.org/en/arthur-streeton/still-glides-the-stream-and-shall-for-ever-glide-1890 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The winding river prevents the valley from settling into stacked horizontal strips. Its changing width establishes depth while nearer trees interrupt, but do not close, the prospect. Streeton makes an expansive view readable through one continuous route. The picture's space depends on this constructed relation between an obstructed foreground and an open distance, rather than on openness alone.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Railway Station, Redfern

Arthur Streeton

1893 · Oil on canvas · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Arthur Streeton. The railway station, Redfern. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Full source frame, proportional resize and JPEG compression. https://www.wikiart.org/en/arthur-streeton/the-railway-station-redfern-1893 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Wet ground connects people who remain separate in the street. Their dark bodies repeat below as reflections, spreading movement across the grey foreground. Smoke and damp air soften the railway buildings, so solid architecture does not dominate the scene entirely. Weather changes the city's visual structure, making transient surfaces as important as the station's permanent forms.

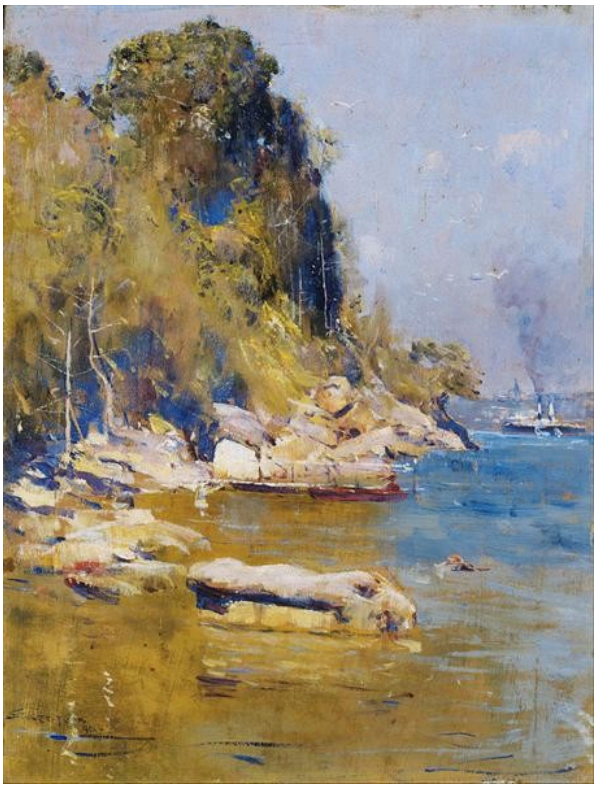
Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

From My Camp (Sirius Cove)

Arthur Streeton

1896 · Oil on plywood · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Arthur Streeton. From my camp (Sirius Cove). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Full source frame, proportional resize and JPEG compression. https://www.wikiart.org/en/arthur-streeton/from-my-camp-sirius-cove-1896 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The cove begins with individual rocks close at hand, then opens toward small boats on blue water. A steep wooded bank limits the view, concentrating attention at the meeting of shade and sunlight. Streeton gives this harbour scene a more bodily scale than the broad river prospect. Distance remains present, but it must be approached through a specific piece of shore.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Antibes

John Russell

1890-1892 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



John Russell. Antibes. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Yellow cliffs, pink buildings and green sea establish the coast before any small detail becomes necessary. Russell lets broad colour areas distinguish foreground, settlement and water. Their contacts do much of the work an outline might otherwise perform. The place stays recognisable while the surface remains an arrangement of emphatically separate painted passages.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Rough Sea, Morestil

John Russell

1900 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



John Russell. Rough sea, Morestil. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The strokes turn around coastal rocks with the moving water. Their changes of direction keep the blue-green surface unsettled even where a complete wave cannot be isolated. Russell distributes motion through the paint rather than concentrating it in one spectacular crest. Dark rock provides the resistance against which that mobile surface can be understood.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Mon Ami 'Polite

John Russell

1900 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



John Russell. Mon ami 'Polite. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Blue passes through beard and clothes into the sea behind, giving portrait and coast a shared handling. The long tool and the man's firm grip nevertheless keep his body distinct within that texture. Russell connects a person to a place without dissolving either into the other. A practical object provides the pose with its clearest direction.

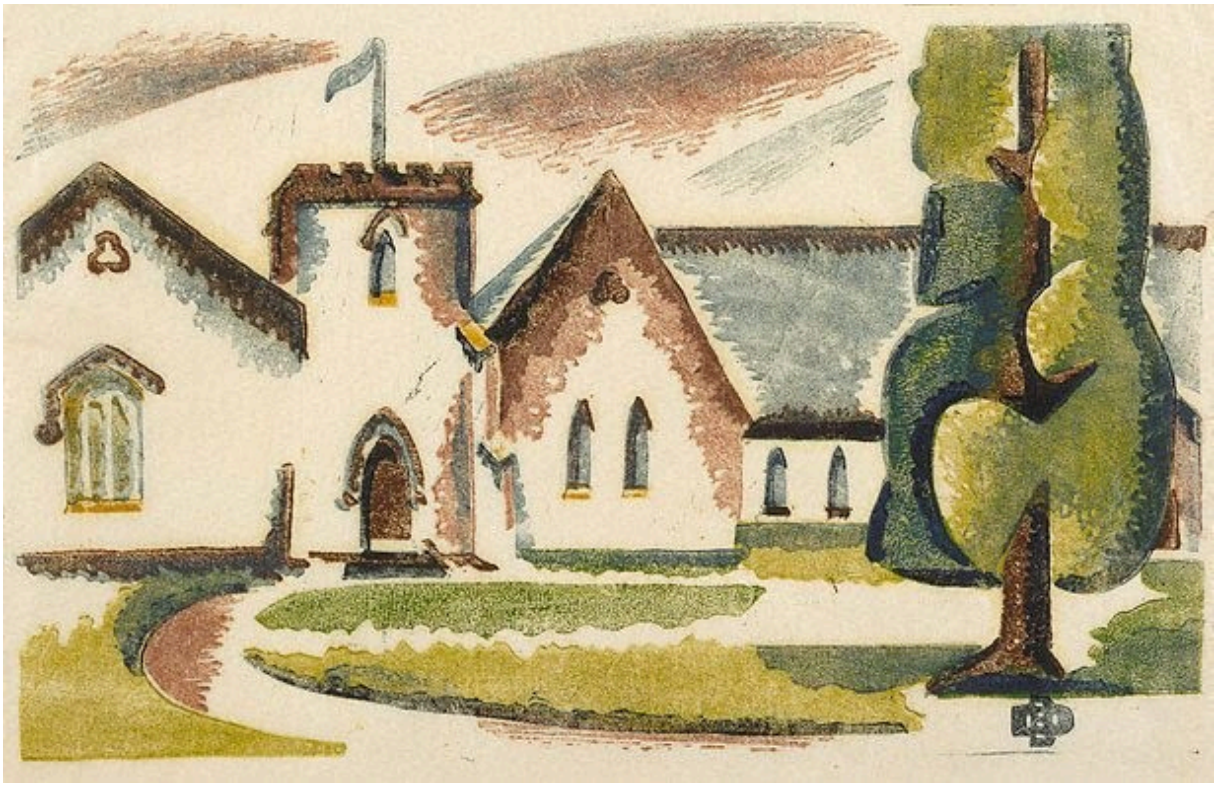
Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

The Parish Hall

Dorrit Black

1937 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Dorrit Black. The Parish Hall. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Pointed roofs and straight walls meet a curved path and clipped green garden forms. Dorrit Black simplifies the view by preserving those differences rather than by giving every surface equal detail. Windows repeat the architecture's angular rhythm. The building retains its character because a few chosen relations between garden and structure remain specific.

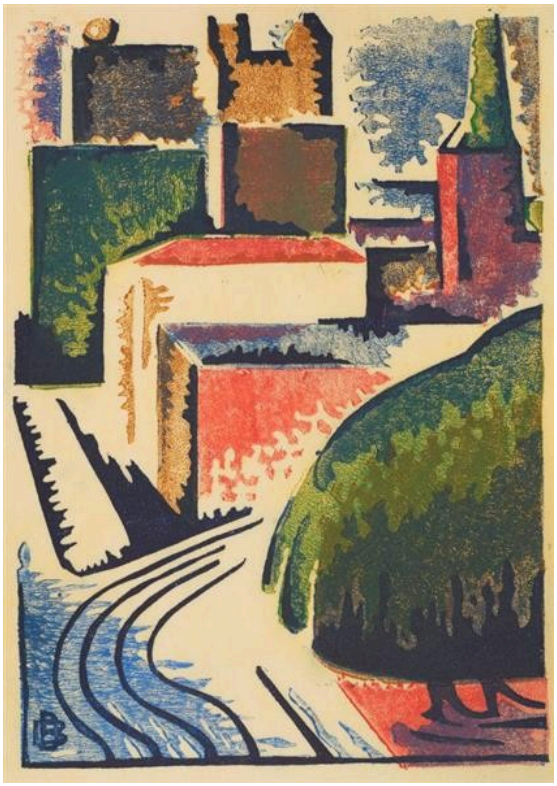
Object source · Open artwork

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Elizabeth Street, Sydney

Dorrit Black

1939 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Dorrit Black. Elizabeth Street, Sydney. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The tracks supply a curve through compressed blocks of red, cream and green. Tilted buildings and trees make the street's movement a property of the whole arrangement, not merely of vehicles or pedestrians. Black removes much incidental description while retaining the forces that direct a city view: routes, repeated angles and the interruption of one mass by another.

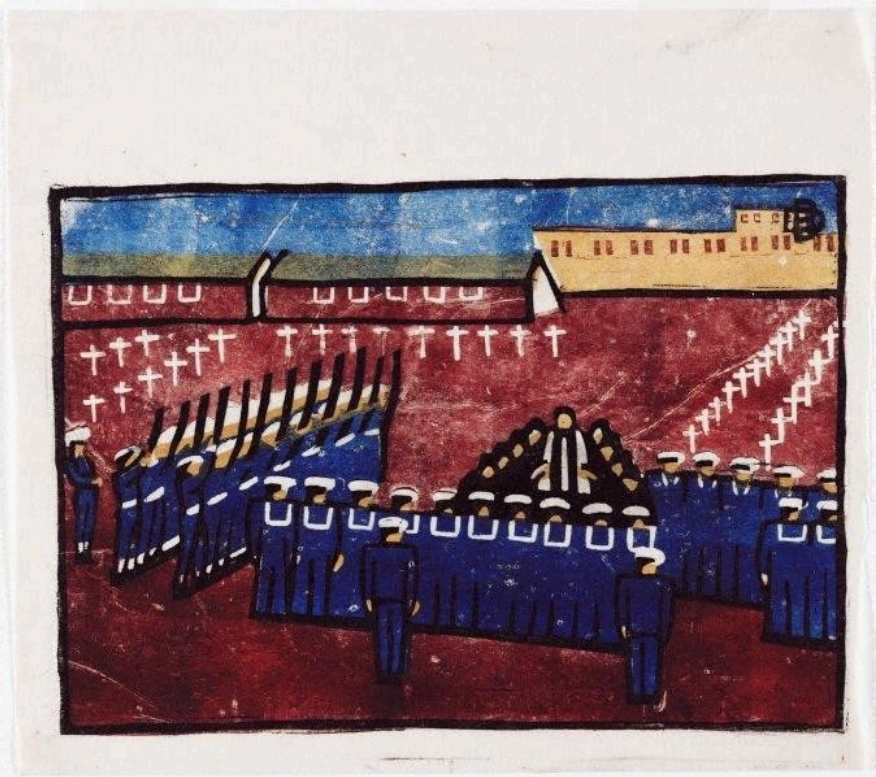
Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Naval Funeral

Dorrit Black

1945 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Dorrit Black. Naval Funeral. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Dark hats and white crosses repeat across a red field, turning bodies into the ordered units of a collective ceremony. Individual figures remain visible, but rank determines their relation to one another. The picture's regularity belongs to its subject. A funeral's shared public form is made legible through the suppression of freely chosen positions and movements.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

David's First Victory

William Strutt

1868 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



William Strutt. David's first victory. Image credit: William Strutt (1825 - 1915) – creator Born in Teignmouth, Devonshire, England. Died in Wadhurst, East Sussex, England. Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: rAHycKA0dYmQBg at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

David's bare legs stand above the mass of the fallen lion, whose mane occupies the near ground. The unequal scale gives the feat its immediate terms: a smaller body has overcome a larger one. The raised hand completes the staged account of victory. Strutt makes the biblical episode comprehensible through proportion before detailed narrative explanation is supplied.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 76.1974

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Fern Gully with Aboriginal Family

Thomas Clark

1863 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Thomas Clark. Fern gully with Aboriginal family. Image credit: Thomas Clark (circa 1814 - 1883) – creator Born in London, England. Died in South Yarra, Melbourne, Victoria, Australia. Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: OQESJm1KWLE8pw at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The Aboriginal family occupies a small part of a gully dominated by arching ferns. That reduced scale directs attention toward vegetation, but it does not make the land uninhabited. Reading a colonial landscape requires holding those two facts together. The painter's distribution of space is a choice about visibility, not a neutral measure of whose presence matters.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: OA27.1970

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A Billabong of the Goulburn, Victoria

Henry James Johnstone

1884 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



1835-1907, Henry James Johnstone. A billabong of the Goulburn, Victoria. Image credit: H.J. Johnstone (1835 - 1907) – creator Born in Birmingham, Warwickshire, England. Died in London, England. Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: pgHo2TGml7JaNw at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Reflected trees extend the dark bank downward, deepening the enclosure around still water. A pale opening beyond becomes unusually important because so much of the view closes around it. Johnstone uses reflection to construct space rather than simply repeat objects. The picture's principal route into distance remains narrow, held between the framing trees and their doubles.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 5771

13 / 20

Stalagmites, Burragalong Cavern

Conrad Martens

1843 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Conrad Martens. Stalagmites, Burragalong Cavern. Image credit: Conrad Martens (1801 - 1878) – creator Born in London, England. Died in North Sydney, New South Wales, Australia. Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: WQHbDtXpn1ifAQ at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Light catches irregular stone edges, allowing formations to emerge separately from the cavern's darkness. A small figure supplies a measure that the underground view would otherwise lack. Martens gives enclosed space the recession of a landscape. What can be seen depends on a few illuminated boundaries rather than on the broad light of an open sky.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: OA1.1964

14 / 20

Self-Portrait

Nicholas Chevalier

1857 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Nicholas Chevalier. Self portrait. Image credit: Nicholas Chevalier; Source credit: https://www.artgallery.nsw.gov.au/collection/works/945/. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Chevalier's wide hat enlarges the silhouette while much of his face remains in shadow. Eyes, cheek and beard receive enough light to establish a likeness without equal clarity everywhere. The dark mass surrounding those features sends attention back toward them. The self-portrait demonstrates how selective illumination can concentrate presence rather than simply withhold information.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 945

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Portrait of Inez Bensusan

Cecil William Rea

1924 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Cecil William Rea. Portrait of Inez Bensusan. Image credit: Cecil William Rea died 1935; Source credit: https://www.artgallery.nsw.gov.au/collection/works/OB1.1968/. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The gathered hands anchor the lower part of the green-clad figure, while Bensusan's head turns away from the body's direction. That small difference keeps the pose from becoming fixed in a single line. Rea gives the lit face room to act independently of the settled posture. The portrait's activity lies in this modest adjustment rather than in overt gesture.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: OB1.1968

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Waiting

Gordon Coutts

1896 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Gordon Coutts. Waiting. Image credit: Gordon Coutts; Source credit: 6wGRrRzA1P4jEA at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The title identifies an interval, but gives no certain account of what will end it. Hands rest on the chair while the pale dress catches window light. The landscape continues beyond the room, offering a direction the seated figure does not follow. Coutts sustains the pause through the relation between an available view and a body remaining still.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 5893

17 / 20

The Visit of the Queen of Sheba to King Solomon

Sir Edward John Poynter

1890 · Oil on canvas · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Sir Edward John Poynter. The visit of the Queen of Sheba to King Solomon. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/edward-poynter/the-visit-of-the-queen-of-sheba-to-king-solomon-1890 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Repeated columns provide a framework for an abundance of steps, costumes and assembled figures. Poynter's imagined ancient court needs that order to make the royal meeting locatable within the spectacle. Architecture is an active narrative device here. It distributes attention and establishes rank, rather than merely supplying an elaborate background behind the principal actors.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Snowdrop and the Seven Little Men

John D. Batten

1897 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



John D. Batten. Snowdrop and the seven little men. Image credit: Own work sailko. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The heroine's long sleeping body lies across the foreground, slowing the arrangement of smaller figures behind. Warm reds and golds connect them to a decorated interior. Batten gives the fairy tale a held moment instead of continuous action. The contrast between the horizontal sleeper and the gathered observers allows stillness itself to organise the scene.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1113

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Mucius Scaevola

Matthias Stom

c.1640 - c. 1645 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Matthias Stom. Mucius Scaevola. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/matthias-stom/mucius-scaevola · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The hand held over the flames is both the action and the source of the scene's illumination. Light spreads from that test of endurance across faces and clothing before reaching darkness. Stom concentrates the Roman story's moral claim into a small, exposed part of the body. The surrounding gathering witnesses an act whose physical cost remains central.

Object source · Open artwork

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At Lilydale

Louis Buvelot

1870 · Art Gallery of New South Wales



Louis Buvelot. At Lilydale. Image credit: Louis Buvelot (1814 - 1888) – creator Born in Morges, Switzerland. Died in Melbourne, Victoria, Australia. Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: swHxc1c_UePU6w at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Cut branches and uneven ground complicate the foreground before the track opens toward fields and hills. Buvelot gives the settled prospect a worked surface close at hand. The landscape is therefore more than a smooth view into distance. Its near edge retains traces of material alteration, making the route outward begin among things that have been handled or cut.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 244.1990

Notice what the scale leaves small

Return to a landscape and locate its people, routes or signs of work before following the distant view. The image may give them less space than their importance warrants. This selection is not a guide to current gallery rooms; confirm the display of individual works with the museum before making a visit plan.

Further reading

The Elements of Drawing

John Ruskin · Read free · English

John Ruskin's Elements of Drawing offers exercises in looking at trees, water, light and distance. Read it beside the landscapes here as a historical drawing manual, not as a guide to Australian history.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Art Gallery of New South Wales: Masterpieces